that the US would not have a 'power sharing' arrangement with the Taliban to foreign secretary Rao on the day of the conference.[84] Indeed, former US secretary of state (2005–09) Condoleezza Rice had sent multiple directives in 2008 to all US diplomats in the region clarifying Washington's differences with the British approach on reconciliation. The US had been clear that the reconciliation process had to be Afghan-led and Afghan-owned.[85] Holbrooke, however, made it clear to both Narayanan and Rao that the US disagreed with Indian assessment that reintegration of Taliban fighters would lead to a Taliban takeover of parts of Afghanistan.

Refusing to accept the outcomes of the London conference (no matter whether the NSA was Narayanan or Menon), India crafted a dual approach to reconcile the evolving international postures on Afghanistan with its desire to balance Afghanistan and Pakistan. Publicly, India began supporting the international community's efforts in finding a political solution to the Afghan conflict, but privately, Indian diplomats began to pressure the US not to leave Afghanistan in a rush or get tricked by Pakistan. On 22 February 2010, MEA joint secretary Yash K. Sinha told his US counterpart to beware of Pakistan's 'game' of enlisting US government support to 'drive India out of Afghanistan'.[86] Sinha warned that Pakistan was treating Indian presence in Afghanistan as a 'zero-sum' game, and was likely to present Washington with 'fabricated' evidence of alleged Indian misbehavior in Afghanistan and in the FATA (a claim that was corroborated by Afghan NSA Rassoul and foreign minister Rangin Dafdar Spanta in a separate meeting with US officials in July 2009).[87] Agreeing that some form of political process was required with the Taliban, Sinha contested that a precipitate US exit would embolden 'fanatics' to think that they had defeated both the USSR and the US—the result of which would be catastrophic for the region.[88]

Three days later, on 25 February 2010, Menon told US senator Claire McCaskill that he may be a 'minority of one', but thought there was more potential for success in Afghanistan than most observers in India think. 'The British were convinced the coalition would lose because they lost three wars there, but others had been able to tame the country', said Menon.[89] The very next day, an unusually 'candid' General V. K. Singh (then in transition from being the